

FERPA-Safe Prompting Cheat Sheet

Quick gut check before you hit send: would this tell a stranger exactly who this kid is?

The Rule

Names, school ID numbers, birthdays, home addresses, exact IEP or 504 details — none of that goes into a public AI tool. Ever. Whatever you type can get stored somewhere you don't control, and you can't pull it back out once it's in.

Separate Who a Student Is From What They Need

The AI doesn't need to know which kid you're talking about. It just needs enough to actually help you.

First, strip out anything identifying

- Names, initials, nicknames
- Class period, school name, anything that narrows it down to one kid
- The exact diagnosis

Then describe the need, not the diagnosis

- Just call them "Student A" or "Learner B"
- Grade level and subject is usually enough context
- Say what they need help with — reading level, specific accommodation — not what the diagnosis is called

✗ Not Safe "Write a scaffold for Macus Miller who has an IEP".	✓ Safe "Write a scaffold for Student A, reading at a 4th grade level".
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One More Look Before You Hit Send

- ☐ No real name, initials, or nickname anywhere in the prompt
- ☐ No class period, school name, or schedule details
- ☐ Diagnosis is described, not named
- ☐ Student shows up as a placeholder, not a person